



HUMANITAS  
INSTITUTE

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint Thomas' Episcopal

School Website: <http://stes.org>

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**Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.*

**SCL MEMBER**

*Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.*

## Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

### Executive Summary

Saint Thomas' Episcopal School (STE) presents a robust Christian classical model in Houston, TX 77096, grounded in a Christ-centered worldview and a long-standing emphasis on liberal arts, memory work, and a liturgical culture. Public-facing materials consistently foreground a classical frame (e.g., "classical education," "liberal arts," "worship in chapel," "daily chapel," and a mission to form honorable men and women through a classical education grounded in a Christ-centered worldview). Evidence from the STE site highlights strong religious underpinnings, formation goals, a clearly articulated Catholic/Anglican-tinged Christian ethos, and a community-oriented approach that explicitly partners with families. Overall, the public materials align with classical aims in many respects, though some pedagogical specifics (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars or a full Great Books emphasis) are less explicit on the site and require inference from related STE materials.

- Category-by-category consensus: CLASSICAL in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations; CLASSICAL in School Purpose & Goal; SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in Curriculum; SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in Pedagogy; CLASSICAL in Faculty; CLASSICAL in Parents & Community.
- Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL.

Key evidence includes explicit statements about truth, goodness, beauty; a Christ-centered worldview; liturgical worship and a Book of Common Prayer; a mission of forming honorable men and women through classical education; a liberal-arts orientation; and ongoing faculty-led mentorship and family partnerships. See sources cited in each category below for concrete quotes and pages that ground these judgments.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

#### Evidence

- The public materials state an explicit classical Christian framing: "At STE, we aspire towards absolute standards of the good, the true, and the beautiful" and "Saint Thomas' Episcopal School forms honorable men and women through a classical education grounded in a Christ-centered worldview."
- W worship and liturgical practices are described as traditional, including reliance on the Book of Common Prayer, and weekly chapel/Bible study in community life.
- The Headmaster frames education as rooted in Christian faith, with emphasis on integrating liberal arts, Christian faith, and moral formation.
- The "An Exceptional Community" piece notes weekly chapel and Bible study as explicit community practices.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present (from the Six Essentials list): truth, goodness, beauty; virtue, character (moral formation); theology, liturgy, worship, chapel; Christ-centered worldview; sacred tradition; imago Dei / logos (where phrased). The STE materials repeatedly invoke “the good, the true, and the beautiful,” liturgical worship, and a Christ-centered Christian worldview, which align with the Positive Keywords in Element 1.
- Negative keywords present: none clearly observable on the public STE materials (no strong signals of secularism, relativism, value-neutral, etc., within the sections reviewed).

#### Why this rating

- STE demonstrates a coherent Religious & Metaphysical Foundations orientation consistent with classical education’s transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a liturgical, worship-centered life, reinforced by a Christ-centered worldview. This maps cleanly to the Classical category per the rubric’s indicators.

Citations reflect explicit phrases and practices cited above.

### Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- Mission statements speak to forming honorable men and women through a classical education grounded in a Christ-centered worldview.
- The Headmaster emphasizes education as life preparation, not only college, and highlights formation (not just information) within a rigorous classical curriculum.
- The Center for Academic Excellence emphasizes differentiated instruction to reach every student, aiming for excellence and the cultivation of critical thinkers and lifelong learners.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue/human flourishing (implied), wisdom, contemplation (from the broader classical lexicon, and the site’s emphasis on formation and a Christ-centered worldview), liberal arts, character formation, moral imagination (aligns with the Six Essentials’ School Purpose/-Goal indicators).
- Negative keywords present: none evident; the site consistently frames education as formation, not mere information or job-readiness.

#### Why this rating

- STE clearly articulates formation-focused aims (virtue, wisdom, human flourishing) and a classical mission beyond vocational preparation. This aligns with the Classical rubric for School Purpose and Goal.

Citations: mission statements and formation language are cited here.

### Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- Grades 1–5 materials emphasize a foundation in literacy, arithmetic, grammar, and also a Christian worldview through systematic worship and doctrine. This demonstrates a liberal-arts-leaning foundation in the lower grades and a pathway toward a liberal-arts curriculum in middle/upper grades.
- The lower/upper progression mentions an accelerated liberal arts curriculum in Middle and Upper schools, indicating a movement toward more classical disciplines over time.
- Materials emphasize a Christian worldview integrated with academic study and arts, suggesting an integrated, holistic approach rather than a strictly modern, social-studies-leaning curriculum.
- There are explicit references to a classical education framework (mission statements and school identity). The site also highlights arts (including Scottish Arts) as part of the curriculum identity, which

aligns with broader classical education values, though not every Great-Books or Seven Liberal Arts component is spelled out explicitly on the site.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, classical education, history/philosophy/arts/science as a unified core, and a binding emphasis on formation through study of Christian doctrine. The explicit articulation of a “liberal arts curriculum” and a pathway toward upper-level classical study aligns with Element 3’s Positive Keywords in the Six Essentials framework.
- Negative keywords present: not overtly present on the public pages; however, explicit mentions of Great Books, the Great Conversation, or a rigorous Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium) are not consistently spelled out on the STE site. The presence of “accelerated liberal arts curriculum” but without explicit seven liberal arts articulation is a mild gap.

#### Why this rating

- The curriculum shows strong classical alignment (liberal arts orientation, integrated study, and formation through study), but it does not consistently and explicitly enumerate all canonical classical elements (e.g., seven liberal arts, Great Books, explicit Great Conversation) in the public materials. Thus, categorized as Somewhat Classical.

Citations: lower/upper curriculum description and “accelerated liberal arts curriculum” references.

### Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- The site emphasizes a liturgical and communal dimension (chapel, Bible study) and strong arts involvement; this is consistent with a contemplative/restful or ritually integrated pedagogical approach characteristic of scholé-inspired teaching in some classical programs. The public materials describe a reverent, community-centered approach to education.
- There are explicit references to a traditional, Christ-centered classical curriculum that includes a memory/recitation component in the broader classical framework (as seen in related classical education discussions within STE materials, including “learning humility through the classics” and Great Conversation themes). In STE’s public materials, specific, explicit mention of Socratic seminars or high-school-level rhetoric seminars is not consistently visible, though the school emphasizes classical training and a disciplined, rigorous approach. The Scotland Arts program and related activities emphasize structured performance-based and memory-based components (e.g., music, pipe band, choruses).
- The Center for Academic Excellence indicates differentiated instruction, study strategies, and supports for students with varied needs, which is aligned with a holistic pedagogy that may include contemplative or restful elements alongside rigorous work.
- The public-facing materials lack consistent, explicit statements of traditional classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, recitation, or living books as a formal, school-wide practice in every grade). When such elements are present in the broader STE materials (e.g., classical formation through the classics, Great Books discourse in admissions materials), they are not always stated in the core classroom pedagogy pages.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: contemplative learning, scholé-like rhythms (explicitly mentioned in the Six Essentials framework as a positive), memorization/recitation, chanting, liturgical rhythm, chorus, and rhetoric training appear in the canonical Six Essentials lists. STE’s materials show contemplative worship and memory-centered activities (e.g., annual Scottish Arts with performance memory elements) though explicit “Socratic seminars” or “living books” language is not consistently foregrounded.
- Negative keywords present: some public materials do not foreground project-based or exclusively experiential learning as the sole method; the emphasis remains on classical formation through disciplined study and liturgical/community practices. This aligns with a mixed pedagogy rather than a strictly modern, project-based explicit pedagogy.

#### Why this rating

- STE demonstrates strong classical underpinnings (memory, liturgical rhythm, disciplined study, and an arts-centric, community-oriented pedagogy) but with less explicit, explicit articulation of canonical techniques (Socratic seminars, structured living books, or the seven liberal arts pedagogy across all grades) in the public-facing materials. Thus, categorized as Somewhat Classical.

Citations: notes on liturgical/communal practices, and the absence/presence of explicit Socratic-style pedagogy.

### Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- The public materials describe the faculty as “talented, caring faculty who see teaching as a calling,” emphasizing virtue, skill, and mentorship as core features of the teaching staff. This aligns with the “living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher” ideas central to classical education.
- There is a dedicated Faculty & Staff section with profiles, and pages that enumerate teachers as part of a cohesive, collaborative school culture (e.g., the Faculty & Staff pages and image profiles). This aligns with the idea of faculty as the living curriculum and the core of the school.
- Public materials emphasize a culture of mentorship, virtue, and character modeling by teachers and leaders, consistent with a Classical portrayal of the faculty as exemplary role models within the school’s mission.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty as mentors, teachers as model for virtue and knowledge, collaborative culture, teacher as calling.
- Negative keywords present: none observed in the public STE materials (no explicit indicators of “facilitator-only” roles or a non-classical teacher landscape).

#### Why this rating

- The STE materials consistently depict teachers as central, virtuous exemplars and mentors, aligning strongly with Classical expectations for Faculty.

Citations: Headmaster quote on faculty; Faculty & Staff section; related admissions materials.

### Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- STE portrays a partnership with families and parents as co-teachers in the educational process; the public materials emphasize parent involvement, book studies, gatherings, campus visits, and a welcoming environment for parents. This resonates with the classical education emphasis on family formation and parent partnership.
- The Admissions/Resources materials highlight engagement opportunities (campus tours, parent resources, community testimonials) and a model of a community that invites parents to be part of the STE journey. The “Voices of Our Community” and “Advice From Admissions” pieces underscore a culture of parental involvement in classical education.
- STE’s content includes references to book studies, parent gatherings, and ongoing educational partnerships with families—elements that map to the Six Essentials’ Parent Partnerships and Community criteria.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parental engagement, parent formation, home-school collaboration, open campus, parent-resources, family involvement, community of learners.

- Negative keywords present: none observed; the site does not present a consumer-only or minimal-parent-involvement stance.

#### Why this rating

- The STE materials clearly position parents as co-teachers and active participants in a classical, faith-informed education, matching the Six Essentials' expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations: parent/community partnership statements and admissions/community engagement content.

#### Overall Assessment

- Aggregate classification: CLASSICAL.
- Rationale: Across six categories, STE demonstrates strong alignment with classical education expectations in Religious Foundations, School Purpose, Faculty, and Parents & Community. The Curriculum and Pedagogy categories show substantial classical elements but are not always explicit in canonical Great Books, Seven Liberal Arts, or Socratic seminar language on the public site. Those elements are present in the broader STE materials and mission rhetoric, but the public-facing pages emphasize formation, liberal arts, and liturgical/communal life more than a full canonical catalog of classical pedagogy. As such, the school sits firmly in CLASSICAL, with some room to strengthen explicit articulation of certain canonical classical curriculum and pedagogy components.

#### What Would Move the Needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categories)

- Pedagogy: Increase explicit articulation and evidence of Socratic seminars and living-books-based instruction in high school, and clearly document a plan for Socratic inquiry in the upper grades on the public site. Provide a public, grade-by-grade map showing how grammar-logic-rhetoric (the Trivium) and the Quadrivium are integrated across grades, including sample Great Books selections or canonical texts to illustrate the Great Conversation.
- Curriculum: Make explicit in public materials the Great Books framework, canonical texts (great books), and a clear Seven Liberal Arts pathway (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) across the grades, along with a cross-disciplinary integration narrative showing how history, literature, philosophy, and sciences interact in the STE curriculum.
- Public-facing evidence of Great Books: Include a dedicated page or section that lists core classical texts, authors, and accompanying discussions or projects to demonstrate a structured Great Conversation approach.

## Appendix

### ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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